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A Single-Parent Postpartum Planner

Forty-four pages for the version of you doing this on your own. Whether by choice, by donor, by circumstance, by loss, by separation, or because the partner is deployed. The village-build page. The night-shift solo plan. The "who do I call for what" list. The financial-aid index. A page for the friends and family who keep asking how they can help.

Soothemade Notes

A S M A L L A P O T H E C A R Y O F P R I N T A B L E S · M A D E S L O W L Y

A note from me

The first time I bought a postpartum planner, I had to mentally translate every page. "Ask your partner to handle the night feeds." "Have your partner take the baby for a walk." "Set up a co-parenting schedule with your partner." On every page, the word "partner" was the assumption I did not have.

About a quarter of mothers in the US are single parents. Many of you are single because the partner is gone. Some of you are single by choice, by donor, by surrogacy. Some of you have a partner who is technically present but functionally not, because of deployment, illness, addiction, or the kind of distance that lives inside a marriage. Some of you became single during pregnancy or after.

This planner is for you. It does not assume the partner. Where help exists in your life, the planner names it specifically (your mother, a paid postpartum doula, the neighbor with a key, the friend who texts every morning) so the village shows up by name, not by the word "partner" that does not apply.

This planner does not have an opinion about how you got here. It just assumes you are here, doing this, and that the work is real and is yours.

Soothemade

This is a planning tool, not medical advice. If anything is physically wrong or you are in crisis, please call a real provider or one of the lines at the back.

A small framing, before anything else

A single parent in postpartum is doing the work of two roles plus the recovery. There is no scenario in which this is a fair amount of work. The goal of this planner is not to make it fair. It is to make it survivable, and then sustainable, and then something close to good.

Three things I would put at the front of every page:

One.

Help is not a moral failure. The people who can do this without help are not better. They are usually just better at hiding the cost. Asking for help is the work. Receiving help is also the work.

Two.

The “village” is real, but it does not arrive on its own. You build it. You build it from named people: a friend, a neighbor, a sibling, a paid helper, a phone hotline. Not “everyone.” Specifically these few.

Three.

You are allowed to spend money on help if you have any. You are allowed to apply for assistance if you don’t. The financial-aid page at the back is not a last resort. It is a Tuesday in week three.

The village-build page

Fill this in during the third trimester (or, if the baby is here, this week).

THE VILLAGE, BY NAME

IN-HOUSE HELP (people who will physically be in my house during the first six weeks, paid or family)

Name: _____ Days: ____ Hours: _____

Name: _____ Days: ____ Hours: _____

Name: _____ Days: ____ Hours: _____

DROP-BY HELP (people who can come for 1-2 hours, bring food, hold the baby briefly, walk the dog)

Name: _____ Best contact: _____

Name: _____ Best contact: _____

Name: _____ Best contact: _____

PHONE-CALL LIFELINES (people I can call at 3am, or after a hard appointment, who will not freak out)

Name: _____ Phone: _____

Name: _____ Phone: _____

Name: _____ Phone: _____

THE NEIGHBOR(S) WHO HAVE A KEY

Name: _____ Phone: _____

Name: _____ Phone: _____

THE PAID HELPERS I AM USING (or considering)

Postpartum doula: _____ Hours: ____

Night nurse: _____ Nights: ____

Cleaning help: _____ Frequency: ____

Meal delivery: _____ Days: ____

A NOTE: my village is bigger than it feels at 3am. The list above contains ____ people. That is more than zero. The list is the truth. The 3am loneliness is the body, not the data.

If the list has fewer than five names, that is the first project for this week. Add to it. Even acquaintances. Even people you would not have called before. The bar is "person who has been kind to me in the past year."

The “who do I call for what” list

A table you tape to the inside of a cabinet.

SCENARIO

WHO TO CALL

I need someone NOW (medical) 911 or local ER
I need someone NOW (mental health) 988 (call or text)
 1-833-852-6262 (parent MH)
I have a feeding question Lactation: 1-800-994-9662
 Or: _____
The baby has something I'm not Pediatrician: _____
 sure about
I have a question about myself OB / Midwife: _____
 (physical)
The baby is fussy and I cannot A friend I can call:
 anymore _____
A friend who can come for 1 hour _____
The dog needs a walk Dog walker / neighbor:

I need groceries but cannot leave Grocery service: _____
 the house A friend: _____
I need a meal Meal-delivery service: ____
 Or text: _____
I need an adult to just sit with me A safe person:

 Postpartum Support Intl:
 1-800-944-4773
I cannot stop crying My therapist: _____
 Or: 1-833-852-6262
I am afraid I might hurt the baby 988 immediately
 Or 1-833-852-6262

The point of this list is that at 3am, your brain will not generate it. The cabinet will.

The night-shift solo plan

The hardest, most expensive part of single-parent postpartum is the nights. Two adults can trade. One adult cannot. This page is about making the solo night as efficient as possible.

The bedside setup

Set up once. Reset every evening before sleep.

WITHIN ARM'S REACH OF THE BED, AT NIGHT

- ☐ Water bottle, full
- ☐ A snack (nut bar, banana, anything that does not require kitchen access)
- ☐ Phone, charged
- ☐ Diaper supplies for the bed-side change (or a small changing pad)
- ☐ Two extra burp cloths
- ☐ A small lamp with a low-light bulb (not the overhead)
- ☐ A pen and a small piece of paper (for the things you need to remember in the morning)
- ☐ The baby's safe sleep space, within reach
- ☐ A pacifier or feeding supplies
- ☐ A small "comfort thing" (a soft pillow, an essential oil, anything)

The two-bottle system (if formula or pumped milk)

If you are bottle-feeding, pre-make two bottles each evening for the night feeds. Refrigerate. The night feed becomes:

1. Reach for bottle in the small fridge / cooler bag

2. Brief warming (or room-temp, if pediatrician okays it)
3. Feed
4. Sleep

The 12-minute solo night feed becomes a 5-minute solo night feed.

The “horizontal whenever possible” rule

If you are nursing, lying down to nurse is fully fine for many parents (look up the Safe Sleep Seven if you co-sleep at all, and read it before relying on it). Horizontal nursing recovers about 40 percent of the sleep that vertical-chair nursing loses.

The “I will be a person tomorrow” rule

You will be a person tomorrow IF, tonight, you let some things go. The thing you let go tonight is whichever of these is on your list:

- ☐ Doing the dishes
- ☐ Cleaning up the living room
- ☐ Replying to texts
- ☐ Posting an update
- ☐ Showering before bed (do it in the morning)
- ☐ Folding the laundry
- ☐ Anything that is not feeding the baby, feeding yourself, and sleeping

The household is the next project. The first project is the night.

The financial-aid index

US-focused. Look these up once, during the third trimester or as soon as you can. Programs vary by state.

SOMETHING TO APPLY FOR

ELIGIBILITY (LOOK UP)

WIC (Women, Infants, Children)
Food assistance + formula
Income-based. Most single parents qualify even with full-time work. Apply through your state.

Medicaid (Pregnancy + Postpartum coverage)
Income-based. Many states now cover 12 months postpartum.

State home-visiting nurse programs
Many states offer FREE nurse home visits in postpartum, often universal, not income based. Look up your state's program.

Local diaper bank
No income requirement in most. Search "diaper bank near me."

TANF (Temporary Assistance)
Income-based, by state.

SNAP (food stamps)
Income-based, by state.

Local crisis funds (often church or community-based)
Varies. Some have no income requirement.

Pumping equipment through insurance
Most US insurance plans cover a pump at no cost. Ask your OB.

Postpartum doula scholarships
Look up "postpartum doula scholarship" in your area. Many doula organizations offer reduced or free care for single parents.

Local LGBTQ+ family support If applicable.
(if applicable)

Childcare subsidies By state. Look up.

State emergency rental assistance Look up by state.

EITC (Earned Income Tax Credit) For working single
parents. File even if
not normally required.

Set aside one hour this week. Look up one of these. Apply if eligible. Repeat.

The food plan

A page for the boring but important question: what will you eat for six weeks.

In week 37 of pregnancy (or now, if the baby is here)

THE FREEZER, BUILD IT

- ☐ Three meals you actually like, batched and frozen.

Not aspirational meals. Meals you have eaten and liked.

- ☐ Pre-portioned. Single servings. So that "thaw dinner" is one move, not five.
- ☐ Snacks. Nuts. Granola bars. Frozen smoothie packs.
- ☐ Easy breakfasts. Steel-cut oats in a jar. Frozen pancakes. Whatever you can eat with one hand.

THE PANTRY

- ☐ Three soups in cans (the kind you can eat cold if you have to)
- ☐ Crackers
- ☐ Peanut butter or nut butter
- ☐ A box of cereal you do not mind eating dry
- ☐ Three boxes of pasta + sauce
- ☐ Apples and bananas (replace weekly)

The “drop on the porch” script

For whoever you can ask:

"Hi! I'm three weeks postpartum and not hosting visits yet. If you wanted to be amazing, you could drop a meal on the porch sometime this week. Anything I would eat:

- A roast chicken from the deli
- Soup from anywhere
- A pre-made salad in a box

No need to ring the bell. No need to come in. I'll send you a thank-you when I surface. Thank you for thinking of us."

Send this to three people. At least one will say yes.

A small-business / work re-entry page

If you are also self-employed, freelance, or trying to keep some work moving:

What's realistic

- Week 1: no work. Period.
- Week 2: maybe respond to one critical email per day.
- Week 3: 30 minutes a day if you must.
- Week 4: small projects, no calls.
- Week 5-6: ramp up gently. If you are seeing clients/customers, the first one back is brief.

If you are an employee on leave, this section may not apply. If you can take 12+ weeks of leave, please take it. If you cannot, this section is for you.

The “out of office” you actually send

Hello,

Thank you for your message. I am on a brief leave for the birth of my baby and will be slow to respond through _____ (approximate date).

For urgent matters, please contact _____.

For non-urgent matters, I will get back to you as soon as I can. Thank you for your patience.

Set this BEFORE the baby comes. Set it for two weeks longer than you think you need. You will need the extra week.

The first three client/customer interactions back

Plan them. Each one is briefer than your usual pre-baby version. Build slowly. Do not start with the hardest client.

A page for the friends and family

A page to print, hand out, or send. So that "how can I help?" gets a real answer.

To friends and family,

I'm a single parent in postpartum. Thank you for caring about us. Here are specific ways to help. I am not asking for any of these from any specific person. I am giving you a menu so the asking is easier on both of us.

THE SHORTEST LIST

- ☐ Drop a meal on the porch. No visit required.
Text me when it's there.
- ☐ Walk the dog _____ for 30 minutes.
- ☐ Empty my dishwasher. Just that. Just emptying.
- ☐ Sit with the baby for 90 minutes so I can sleep.
- ☐ Drive me to the pediatrician appointment on _____.
- ☐ Pick up groceries from the list I'll send.
- ☐ Bring me one coffee on a Tuesday morning.
- ☐ Just text me at 9am with a single sentence. Don't expect a reply. The text itself is the help.

THE SLIGHTLY LARGER LIST

- ☐ Take the baby for a stretch (3+ hours) so I can do something else.
- ☐ Come help me sort the paperwork (medical, insurance, etc.).
- ☐ Sit with me. Don't do anything. Just be in the room. Bring a book.

WHAT WOULD NOT BE HELPFUL RIGHT NOW

- × Opinions about my decisions
- × Visits longer than 90 minutes
- × Visits without food
- × Photos posted of us without my okay
- × "How are you" without time to actually hear it

Thank you. I am doing okay. I will tell you when I'm ready for more.

The “what about the other parent” page

Optional. Only for the families where there is a co-parenting situation, an absent parent, a deployment, or a partner who is present but not functional.

If there is no other parent

You can skip this whole page.

If there is a non-custodial parent

COMMUNICATION

How we communicate:

- ☐ Text only
- ☐ Email only
- ☐ Through a co-parenting app: _____
- ☐ Through a lawyer

What I share with them:

- ☐ Major medical updates
- ☐ Photos at a set cadence (___ per ___)
- ☐ Nothing right now

What they share with me:

- ☐ Visit logistics
- ☐ Their availability
- ☐ Nothing right now

BOUNDARIES

Topics that are NOT for our communication:

- ☐ _____
- ☐ _____

My response when they cross a line:

If the other parent is deployed or temporarily absent

HOW WE STAY CONNECTED

Their available windows: _____

How we communicate: _____

What they want to see: ☐ photos ☐ videos ☐ updates

What they don't want yet: _____

WHAT I AM HANDLING ALONE FOR NOW

WHAT I NEED FROM THEM WHEN THEY ARE BACK

If the other parent is here but not functional

This is a harder version of the conversation. A therapist for you (and a family therapist for both of you, if possible) is the gold standard. Until then:

WHAT I AM HANDLING (because they cannot right now)

WHAT THEY ARE HANDLING (be honest, even if it's small)

WHAT I WOULD LIKE TO BE TRUE IN 6 MONTHS

WHAT I AM DOING TODAY ABOUT THAT

A note: if the other parent is unsafe (substance abuse, harm, neglect), you do not owe them participation in this planner. Please prioritize your safety and the baby's. The Childhelp line is **1-800-422-4453** and is confidential.

The check-in page

A page you'll see five times in the planner: end of week 1, week 2, week 4, week 8, week 12.

END OF WEEK ____ / BABY'S AGE: _____

THE BODY

Bleeding (circle): heavy moderate light none

Sleep (circle): crisis broken livable

Eating (circle): not really okay enough

Pain (circle): severe moderate mild none

The hardest physical

thing this week: _____

THE MIND

Mood, in one word: _____

Anxiety (1-10): ____

Crying (this week): ☐ no ☐ once ☐ daily ☐ constant

A thought that kept

coming back: _____

THE VILLAGE

People who showed up

this week: _____

People I asked but

didn't: _____

What I want to ask for

next week: _____

THE WORK (if you have any work to do)

How much I did: ____ % of what I wanted to

What I let go of: _____

ONE THING THAT WAS GOOD THIS WEEK

ONE THING I WANT FOR NEXT WEEK

A page that is just for you

A page at the back. To read in a quiet moment.

You are doing one of the hardest versions of one of the hardest things humans do.

Most of the parenting content in the world assumes two adults. Most of the parenting advice in the world says “ask your partner” as if that is a free move. You are doing it without that.

That is not a footnote on your story. That is a central fact about it. You should be more proud of yourself than you currently are. The math suggests you don’t fully see it from the inside.

Here are three things to write down, if you want, in your own handwriting.

One. What is one thing I have done this week that no one will ever know about?

Two. What is one thing about myself I am only learning now, in this season?

Three. What is one thing the baby will never know about how much I carried this year?

Put it down somewhere. The page can hold it.

Soothemade.

Numbers to keep

PEDIATRICIAN

Name: _____ Number: _____

After-hours line: _____

OB / MIDWIFE / PRIMARY CARE

Name: _____ Number: _____

LACTATION CONSULTANT

Name: _____ Number: _____

THERAPIST (start with one if you don't have one)

Name: _____ Number: _____

POSTPARTUM DOULA (if any)

Name: _____ Number: _____

THREE PEOPLE I CAN CALL AT 3AM

1. _____

2. _____

3. _____

THE NEIGHBOR WITH A KEY

US NATIONAL BREASTFEEDING HELPLINE

1-800-994-9662 (Mon-Fri, English + Spanish)

US MATERNAL MENTAL HEALTH HOTLINE

1-833-852-6262 (24/7, free, confidential)

US SUICIDE & CRISIS LIFELINE

988 (call or text, 24/7)

POSTPARTUM SUPPORT INTERNATIONAL

1-800-944-4773

CHILDHELP NATIONAL HOTLINE

1-800-422-4453 (24/7, free, confidential, anonymous,
for parents struggling)

POISON CONTROL (US)

1-800-222-1222 (24/7)

LOCAL ER

Hospital: _____ Number: _____

A SINGLE-PARENT COMMUNITY (online or local)



From Soothemade Notes, a small apothecary of printables, planners, and cards for the unphotographed parts of new parenthood. Made slowly, in plain language.



Soothemade *Notes*

*Made for the version of you no one tells you about, the
one at four in the morning, the one in the parking lot, the
one who doesn't recognize her own week.*

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